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United States Patent	12414539
Kind Code	B1
Date of Patent	September 16, 2025
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Remote pet treat-dispensing system for use with a mailbox

Abstract

The remote pet treat-dispensing system for use with a mailbox may include a treat dispensing unit and a remote activation unit. The remote pet treat-dispensing system may be adapted to train a dog to behave less aggressively when a mail carrier delivers mail. Responsive to an indication from the remote activation unit that the mail carrier has accessed a mail receptacle, the treat dispensing unit may be adapted to play an audible sound intended to attract the dog to the treat dispensing unit, may activate an air moving device to diffuse the scent of a plurality of dog treats stored within the treat dispensing unit, and may dispense one or more individual dog treats. As non-limiting examples, the mail receptacle may be a mailbox located outside of a building or a mail slot located on a front door.

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Family ID:	1000007781765
Appl. No.:	18/616476
Filed:	March 26, 2024

Publication Classification

Int. Cl.:	A01K5/01 (20060101)
U.S. Cl.:	
CPC	A01K5/0114 (20130101);

Field of Classification Search

CPC:	A01K (5/0114)
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Background/Summary

CROSS REFERENCES TO RELATED APPLICATIONS

(1) Not Applicable

STATEMENT REGARDING FEDERALLY SPONSORED RESEARCH

(2) Not Applicable

REFERENCE TO APPENDIX

(3) Not Applicable

BACKGROUND OF THE INVENTION

Field of the Invention

(4) The present invention relates to the fields of annunciators and pet training systems, more specifically, a remote pet treat-dispensing system for use with a mailbox.

SUMMARY OF INVENTION

(5) The remote pet treat-dispensing system for use with a mailbox may comprise a treat dispensing unit and a remote activation unit. The remote pet treat-dispensing system may be adapted to train a dog to behave less aggressively when a mail carrier delivers mail. Responsive to an indication from the remote activation unit that the mail carrier has accessed a mail receptacle, the treat dispensing unit may be adapted to play an audible sound intended to attract the dog to the treat dispensing unit, may activate an air moving device to diffuse the scent of a plurality of dog treats **930** stored within the treat dispensing unit, and may dispense one or more individual dog treats. As non-limiting examples, the mail receptacle may be a mailbox located outside of a building or a mail slot located on a front door.

(6) An object of the invention is to dispense one or more individual dog treats into a tray from a hopper holding a plurality of dog treats in response to a wireless indication from a remote

activation unit that a mail receptacle door has been moved.

(7) Another object of the invention is to provide a sound transducer operable to play a sound that may attract the dog to a treat dispensing unit.

(8) A further object of the invention is to provide an air-moving device and a rotation motor to blow the scent of the plurality of treats into an area in front of the treat dispensing unit.

(9) Yet another object of the invention is to provide a camera to record the behavior of the dog and to make the recording available wirelessly to the user's smart phone.

(10) These together with additional objects, features and advantages of the remote pet treat-dispensing system for use with a mailbox will be readily apparent to those of ordinary skill in the art upon reading the following detailed description of the presently preferred, but nonetheless illustrative, embodiments when taken in conjunction with the accompanying drawings.

(11) In this respect, before explaining the current embodiments of the remote pet treat-dispensing system for use with a mailbox in detail, it is to be understood that the remote pet treat-dispensing system for use with a mailbox is not limited in its applications to the details of construction and arrangements of the components set forth in the following description or illustration. Those skilled in the art will appreciate that the concept of this disclosure may be readily utilized as a basis for the design of other structures, methods, and systems for carrying out the several purposes of the remote pet treat-dispensing system for use with a mailbox.

(12) It is therefore important that the claims be regarded as including such equivalent construction insofar as they do not depart from the spirit and scope of the remote pet treat-dispensing system for use with a mailbox. It is also to be understood that the phraseology and terminology employed herein are for purposes of description and should not be regarded as limiting.

Description

BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF DRAWINGS

(1) The accompanying drawings, which are included to provide a further understanding of the invention are incorporated in and constitute a part of this specification, illustrate an embodiment of the invention and together with the description serve to explain the principles of the invention. They are meant to be exemplary illustrations provided to enable persons skilled in the art to practice the disclosure and are not intended to limit the scope of the appended claims.

(2) FIG. 1 is an isometric kit view of an embodiment of the disclosure.

(3) FIG. 2 is a front view of an embodiment of the disclosure.

(4) FIG. 3 is a side detail view of an embodiment of the disclosure.

(5) FIG. 4 is a rear view of an embodiment of the disclosure.

(6) FIG. 5 is a detail view of an embodiment of the disclosure.

(7) FIG. 6 is an in-use view of an embodiment of the disclosure.

DETAILED DESCRIPTION OF THE EMBODIMENT

(8) The following detailed description is merely exemplary in nature and is not intended to limit the described embodiments of the application and uses of the described embodiments. As used herein, the word “exemplary” or “illustrative” means “serving as an example, instance, or illustration.” Any implementation described herein as “exemplary” or “illustrative” is not necessarily to be construed as preferred or advantageous over other implementations. All of the implementations described below are exemplary implementations provided to enable persons skilled in the art to practice the disclosure and are not intended to limit the scope of the appended claims. Furthermore, there is no intention to be bound by any expressed or implied theory presented in the preceding technical field, background, brief summary or the following detailed description. As used herein, the word “or” is intended to be inclusive.

(9) Detailed reference will now be made to a first potential embodiment of the disclosure, which is

illustrated in FIGS. 1 through 6.

- (10) The remote pet treat-dispensing system for use with a mailbox **100** (hereinafter invention) comprises a treat dispensing unit **200** and a remote activation unit **260**. The invention **100** may be adapted to train a dog **920** to behave less aggressively when a mail carrier delivers mail. Responsive to an indication from the remote activation unit **260** that the mail carrier has accessed a mail receptacle **900**, the treat dispensing unit **200** may be adapted to play an audible sound **298** intended to attract the dog **920** to the treat dispensing unit **200**, may activate an air moving device **240** to diffuse the scent of a plurality of dog treats **930** stored within the treat dispensing unit **200**, and may dispense one or more individual dog treats **932**. As non-limiting examples, the mail receptacle **900** may be a mailbox located outside of a building or a mail slot located on a front door.
- (11) The treat dispensing unit **200** may comprise an enclosure **210**, a treat dispensing mechanism, a control circuit **230**, a camera **244**, a sound transducer **248**, the air moving device **240**, and a rotation motor **250**. The treat dispensing unit **200** may be adapted to be positioned inside of the building where the treat dispensing unit **200** is accessible by the dog **920**.
- (12) The enclosure **210** may comprise a top housing **212** and a base **216**. The top housing **212** may house the treat dispensing mechanism, the control circuit **230**, the air moving device **240**, the camera **244**, and the sound transducer **248**. The base **216** may elevate the top housing **212** above a floor on a plurality of feet that may stabilize the invention **100**. The top housing **212** may be pivotably coupled to the base **216** such that an azimuth angle **294** of the top housing **212** may be varied.
- (13) The treat dispensing mechanism may comprise a treat hopper **222**, a dispensing chute **226**, a treat release mechanism **228**, and a tray **208**. Upon activation by the control circuit **230**, the treat release mechanism **228** may dispense the one or more individual dog treats **932** from the treat hopper **222** into the tray **208**. The one or more individual dog treats **932** may travel from the treat hopper **222** to the tray **208** via the dispensing chute **226**. The tray **208** may be accessible outside of the top housing **212** on the lower front of the top housing **212**. The tray may be adapted to hold the one or more individual dog treats **932** until the one or more individual dog treats **932** are retrieved by the dog **920**. The treat hopper **222** may be located within the top housing **212**. A refill door **224** on the top housing **212** may be opened in order to place the plurality of dog treats into the treat hopper **222**.
- (14) The treat release mechanism **228** may block the dispensing chute **226** such unless activated by the control circuit **230**. Upon activation, the treat release mechanism **228** may move to permit the one or more individual dog treats **932** to enter the dispensing chute **226** and travel to the tray **208**.
- (15) As non-limiting examples, the treat release mechanism **228** may be a rotating door, a pivoting vane, a flap, or a shutter that may be activated by an electrical signal from the control circuit **230**.
- (16) The control circuit **230** may be an electrical circuit that monitors and controls the operation of the treat dispensing unit **200**. In some embodiments, the control circuit **230** may be microprocessor-based. As non-limiting examples, the control circuit **230** may monitor and control the treat release mechanism **228**, an activation receiver **232**, a communication transceiver **234**, the air moving device **240**, the sound transducer **248**, and the rotation motor **250**.
- (17) The activation receiver **232** may receive a first wireless signal **290** from the remote activation unit **260** indicating that a mail receptacle door **902** of the mail receptacle **900** has been moved, signifying the presence of the mail carrier. Upon receiving the first wireless signal **290** via the activation receiver **232**, the control circuit **230** may initiate a response that comprises activating the camera **244**, activating the sound transducer **248**, activating the air moving device **240** and the rotation motor **250**, activating the treat release mechanism **228**, or any combination thereof.
- (18) The control circuit **230** may be adapted to activate the camera **244** in order to record a video showing the response of the dog **920**. The camera **244** may start recording upon receipt of the first wireless signal **290** and may record for a first pre-defined time interval after activation. The camera **244** may be adapted for a user to review the recorded video on an application program **236**.

executing on a smart phone **940**. The recorded video may be accessed by the application program **236** via a second wireless signal **292** sent between the communication transceiver **234** and the smart phone **940**.

(19) As non-limiting examples, the first wireless signal **290** and the second wireless signal **292** may be Bluetooth, Wi-Fi, NearLink, NFC, LPWAN, ultra-wideband (UWB), IEEE 802.15.4, or any combination thereof.

(20) The sound transducer **248** may be configured to play the audible sound **298** passed to the sound transducer **248** as an electrical audio signal sourced from the control circuit **230**. As non-limiting examples, the sound transducer **248** may be a speaker and the audible sound **298** may be a recording of the dog owner's voice.

(21) The air moving device **240** may be activated to blow a stream of air **296** over the treat hopper **222** and out of the top housing **212** via a front vent aperture **214**. The air moving device **240** may thereby be adapted to emit the scent of the plurality of dog treats **930** from the top housing **212** in order to attract the dog **920**. The air moving device **240** may be energized upon receipt of the first wireless signal **290** and may continue to move the stream of air **296** for a second pre-defined time interval after activation. As a non-limiting example, the air moving device **240** may be a fan.

(22) The control circuit **230** may activate the rotation motor **250** to operate simultaneously with the air moving device **240**. The rotation motor **250** may be operable to pivot the top housing **212** in an oscillatory manner such that the top housing **212** may pivot back and forth to change the azimuth angle **294** of the front vent aperture **214**. The oscillatory motion may increase the spatial volume within the building that is exposed to the scent of the plurality of dog treats **930**. In a preferred embodiment, the top housing **212** may oscillate back and forth through an angle of approximately 60 degrees.

(23) A power source for the treat dispensing unit **200** may be an AC cord **256**.

(24) The remote activation unit **260** may comprise an activation control **262**, a transmitter **264**, and an activation unit battery **266**. The remote activation unit **260** may be coupled to the mail receptacle **900** where the activation control **262** may sense movement of the mail receptacle door **902**. Responsive to movement of the mail receptacle door **902**, the remote activation unit **260** may send the first wireless signal **290** to the activation receiver **232** via the transmitter **264**.

(25) As non-limiting examples, the activation control **262** may be an electromechanical switch comprising electromechanical contacts, a magnetic switch that may sense a change in a magnetic field, an optical switch that may detect an interruption of an optical path, or any combination thereof.

(26) The transmitter **264** may be powered by the activation unit battery **266**.

(27) In use, the remote activation unit **260** may be coupled to a mail receptacle **900** such that the remote activation unit **260** may detect movement of the mail receptacle door **902**. The treat dispensing unit **200** may be placed within the building at a location that is accessible to the dog **920**. The treat hopper **222** may be filled with a plurality of dog treats **930**. Responsive to the mail carrier opening the mail receptacle door **902**, the remote activation unit **260** may transmit the first wireless signal **290** to the activation receiver **232** in the treat dispensing unit **200**.

(28) Upon receiving the first wireless signal **290** via the activation receiver **232**, the control circuit **230** may initiate a response comprising any or all of the following actions, not necessarily in the order shown: The control circuit **230** may activate the camera **244** to record the actions of the dog **920**. The control circuit **230** may activate the sound transducer **248** to play an audible sound **298** intended to attract the dog **920** to the treat dispensing unit **200**. As a non-limiting example, the audible sound **298** may be the dog owner's recorded voice. The control circuit **230** may activate the air moving device **240** to create the stream of air **296** through the treat hopper **222** such that the scent of the plurality of dog treats **930** permeates the space in front of the top housing **212**. The control circuit **230** may activate the rotation motor **250** to cause an oscillatory motion of the top housing **212** in order to direct the scent of the plurality of dog treats **930** into a larger space. The

control circuit **230** may activate the treat release mechanism **228** to dispense one or more individual dog treats **932** into the tray **208**. The control circuit **230** may de-activate the camera **244**, the sound transducer **248**, the air moving device **240**, and the rotation motor **250** after one or more pre-determined time intervals.

(29) The user may review recorded video of the dog **920** and may change the audible sound **298** that plays through the sound transducer **248** via an application program **236** on a smart phone **940**.

Definitions

(30) Unless otherwise stated, the words “up”, “down”, “top”, “bottom”, “upper”, and “lower” should be interpreted within a gravitational framework. “Down” is the direction that gravity would pull an object. “Up” is the opposite of “down”. “Bottom” is the part of an object that is down farther than any other part of the object. “Top” is the part of an object that is up farther than any other part of the object. “Upper” may refer to top and “lower” may refer to the bottom. As a non-limiting example, the upper end of a vertical shaft is the top end of the vertical shaft.

(31) As used in this disclosure, “AC” may be an acronym for alternating current.

(32) As used in this disclosure, an “aperture” may be an opening in a surface or object. Aperture may be synonymous with hole, slit, crack, gap, slot, or opening.

(33) As used in this disclosure, an “application” or “app” may be software that is designed to perform one or more specific tasks on a personal computing device, smart phone, or some other computing device.

(34) As used herein, “approximate” and “approximately” indicate that information that is being presented is not critical for proper functioning of the invention and that the information is being provided only to assist in a better understanding of some physical characteristic of an embodiment of the invention. As a non-limiting example, a device that is described as “cubical and approximately 1 inch long on each side” is not required to be precisely 1 inch long on each side and the reader may understand that the device will likely fit in their pocket.

(35) As used in this disclosure, the “azimuth” or azimuth angle, refers to an angle that is measured in a plane that is perpendicular to the either the vertical direction or the force of gravity.

(36) Throughout this document the terms “battery”, “battery pack”, and “batteries” may be used interchangeably to refer to one or more wet or dry cells or batteries of cells in which chemical energy is converted into electricity and used as a source of DC power. References to recharging or replacing batteries may refer to recharging or replacing individual cells, individual batteries of cells, or a package of multiple battery cells as is appropriate for any given battery technology that may be used. The battery may require electrical contacts which may not be illustrated in the figures.

(37) As used in this disclosure, a “camera” may be a sensor that converts light into electric signals that encode the spatial orientation of the captured light in a manner that reproduces the images seen by a human eye.

(38) As used herein, a “chute” may be a sloping and/or curving channel or slide for conveying things to a lower level.

(39) As used herein, the words “couple”, “couples”, “coupled” or “coupling”, may refer to connecting, either directly or indirectly, and does not necessarily imply a mechanical connection.

(40) As used in this disclosure, a “fan” may be an electromechanical device with rotating blades that is used to create a flow or current of air.

(41) As used herein, “front” may indicate the side of an object that is closest to a forward direction of travel under normal use of the object or the side or part of an object that normally presents itself to view or that is normally used first. “Rear” or “back” may refer to the side that is opposite the front.

(42) As used in this disclosure, a “housing” may be a rigid or semi-rigid casing that encloses and protects one or more devices.

(43) As used in this disclosure, a “motor” may refer to a device that transforms energy from an

external power source into mechanical energy.

(44) As used herein, “oscillatory” or “vibratory” may refer to a rhythmic or repetitious motion.

(45) As used herein, the word “pivot” may include any mechanical arrangement that allows for rotational motion. Non-limiting examples of pivots may include hinges, holes, posts, dowels, pins, points, rods, shafts, balls, and sockets, either individually or in combination.

(46) As used herein, the terms “processor”, “central processor”, “central processing unit”, “CPU”, or “microprocessor” may refer to a digital device that carries out the instructions comprising a computer program by performing basic arithmetic, logical, control, and input/out operations. The term “microprocessor” may additionally imply a level of miniaturization and power reduction that makes the device suitable for portable or battery operated systems.

(47) As used herein, “smart phone” or “smartphone” may refer to a personal communication device that incorporates cellular phone calling and texting capabilities along with advanced features. Non-limiting examples of the advanced features of a smart phone may include camera functions, multimedia functions (such as music and video recording and playback and gaming), internet functions (such as web browsing and file uploading/downloading), and Global Positioning System capabilities. A smartphone may be able to execute downloaded application programs that expand the capabilities of the smartphone.

(48) As used in this disclosure, a “speaker” may be an electrical transducer that converts an electrical signal into an audible sound. A speaker may also be referred to as a loudspeaker.

(49) As used in this disclosure, a “transceiver” may be a device that is used to transmit and/or receive signals. The signals may be audible, optical, or RF in nature.

(50) As used in this disclosure, a “transducer” may be a device that converts a physical quantity, such as pressure or brightness, into an electrical signal or a device that converts an electrical signal into a physical quantity.

(51) As used in this disclosure, “wireless” may be an adjective that is used to describe a communication channel that does not require the use of physical cabling.

(52) With respect to the above description, it is to be realized that the optimum dimensional relationship for the various components of the invention described above and in FIGS. 1 through 6, include variations in size, materials, shape, form, function, and manner of operation, assembly and use, are deemed readily apparent and obvious to one skilled in the art, and all equivalent relationships to those illustrated in the drawings and described in the specification are intended to be encompassed by the invention.

(53) It shall be noted that those skilled in the art will readily recognize numerous adaptations and modifications which can be made to the various embodiments of the present invention which will result in an improved invention, yet all of which will fall within the spirit and scope of the present invention as defined in the following claims. Accordingly, the invention is to be limited only by the scope of the following claims and their equivalents.

Claims

1. A remote pet treat-dispensing system for use with a mailbox comprising: a treat dispensing unit and a remote activation unit; wherein the remote pet treat-dispensing system for use with a mailbox is adapted to train a dog to behave less aggressively when a mail carrier delivers mail; wherein responsive to an indication from the remote activation unit that the mail carrier has accessed a mail receptacle, the treat dispensing unit is adapted to play an audible sound intended to attract the dog to the treat dispensing unit, activate an air moving device to diffuse the scent of a plurality of dog treats stored within the treat dispensing unit, and dispense one or more individual dog treats; wherein the treat dispensing unit comprises an enclosure, a treat dispensing mechanism, a control circuit, a camera, a sound transducer, the air moving device, and a rotation motor; wherein the treat dispensing unit is adapted to be positioned inside of a building where the treat dispensing unit is

accessible by the dog; wherein the enclosure comprises a top housing and a base; wherein the top housing houses the treat dispensing mechanism, the control circuit, the air moving device, the camera, and the sound transducer; wherein the base elevates the top housing above a floor on a plurality of feet that stabilize the remote pet treat-dispensing system for use with a mailbox; wherein the top housing is pivotably coupled to the base such that an azimuth angle of the top housing is variable.

2. The remote pet treat-dispensing system for use with a mailbox according to claim 1 wherein the treat dispensing mechanism comprises a treat hopper, a dispensing chute, a treat release mechanism, and a tray; wherein upon activation by the control circuit, the treat release mechanism dispenses the one or more individual dog treats from the treat hopper into the tray; wherein the one or more individual dog treats travel from the treat hopper to the tray via the dispensing chute.

3. The remote pet treat-dispensing system for use with a mailbox according to claim 2 wherein the tray is accessible outside of the top housing on the lower front of the top housing; wherein the tray is adapted to hold the one or more individual dog treats until the one or more individual dog treats are retrieved by the dog.

4. The remote pet treat-dispensing system for use with a mailbox according to claim 3 wherein the treat hopper is located within the top housing; wherein a refill door on the top housing is opened in order to place the plurality of dog treats into the treat hopper.

5. The remote pet treat-dispensing system for use with a mailbox according to claim 4 wherein the treat release mechanism blocks the dispensing chute such unless activated by the control circuit; wherein upon activation, the treat release mechanism moves to permit the one or more individual dog treats to enter the dispensing chute and travel to the tray.

6. The remote pet treat-dispensing system for use with a mailbox according to claim 5 wherein the treat release mechanism is a rotating door, a pivoting vane, a flap, or a shutter that is activated by an electrical signal from the control circuit.

7. The remote pet treat-dispensing system for use with a mailbox according to claim 5 wherein the control circuit is an electrical circuit that monitors and controls the operation of the treat dispensing unit.

8. The remote pet treat-dispensing system for use with a mailbox according to claim 7 wherein the control circuit monitors and controls the treat release mechanism, an activation receiver, a communication transceiver, the air moving device, the sound transducer, and the rotation motor.

9. The remote pet treat-dispensing system for use with a mailbox according to claim 8 wherein the activation receiver receives a first wireless signal from the remote activation unit indicating that a mail receptacle door of the mail receptacle has been moved; wherein upon receiving the first wireless signal via the activation receiver, the control circuit initiates a response that comprises activating the camera, activating the sound transducer, activating the air moving device, activating the rotation motor, activating the treat release mechanism, or any combination thereof.

10. The remote pet treat-dispensing system for use with a mailbox according to claim 9 wherein the control circuit is adapted to activate the camera in order to record a video showing the response of the dog; wherein the camera starts recording upon receipt of the first wireless signal and records for a first pre-defined time interval after activation; wherein the camera is adapted for a user to review the recorded video on an application program executing on a smart phone; wherein the recorded video is accessed by the application program via a second wireless signal sent between the communication transceiver and the smart phone.

11. The remote pet treat-dispensing system for use with a mailbox according to claim 10 wherein the sound transducer is configured to play the audible sound passed to the sound transducer as an electrical audio signal sourced from the control circuit.

12. The remote pet treat-dispensing system for use with a mailbox according to claim 11 wherein the sound transducer is a speaker and the audible sound is a recording of the dog owner's voice.

13. The remote pet treat-dispensing system for use with a mailbox according to claim 11 wherein

the air moving device is activated to blow a stream of air over the treat hopper and out of the top housing via a front vent aperture; wherein the air moving device is adapted to emit the scent of the plurality of dog treats from the top housing in order to attract the dog; wherein the air moving device is energized upon receipt of the first wireless signal and continues to move the stream of air for a second pre-defined time interval after activation.

14. The remote pet treat-dispensing system for use with a mailbox according to claim 13 wherein the air moving device is a fan.

15. The remote pet treat-dispensing system for use with a mailbox according to claim 13 wherein the control circuit activates the rotation motor to operate simultaneously with the air moving device; wherein the rotation motor is operable to pivot the top housing in an oscillatory manner such that the top housing pivots back and forth to change the azimuth angle of the front vent aperture; wherein the oscillatory motion increases the spatial volume within the building that is exposed to the scent of the plurality of dog treats.

16. The remote pet treat-dispensing system for use with a mailbox according to claim 13 wherein the remote activation unit comprises an activation control, a transmitter, and an activation unit battery; wherein the remote activation unit is coupled to the mail receptacle where the activation control senses movement of the mail receptacle door; wherein responsive to movement of the mail receptacle door, the remote activation unit sends the first wireless signal to the activation receiver via the transmitter.

17. The remote pet treat-dispensing system for use with a mailbox according to claim 16 wherein the activation control is an electromechanical switch comprising electromechanical contacts, a magnetic switch that senses a change in a magnetic field, an optical switch that detects an interruption of an optical path, or any combination thereof.

18. The remote pet treat-dispensing system for use with a mailbox according to claim 16 wherein the transmitter is powered by the activation unit battery.
